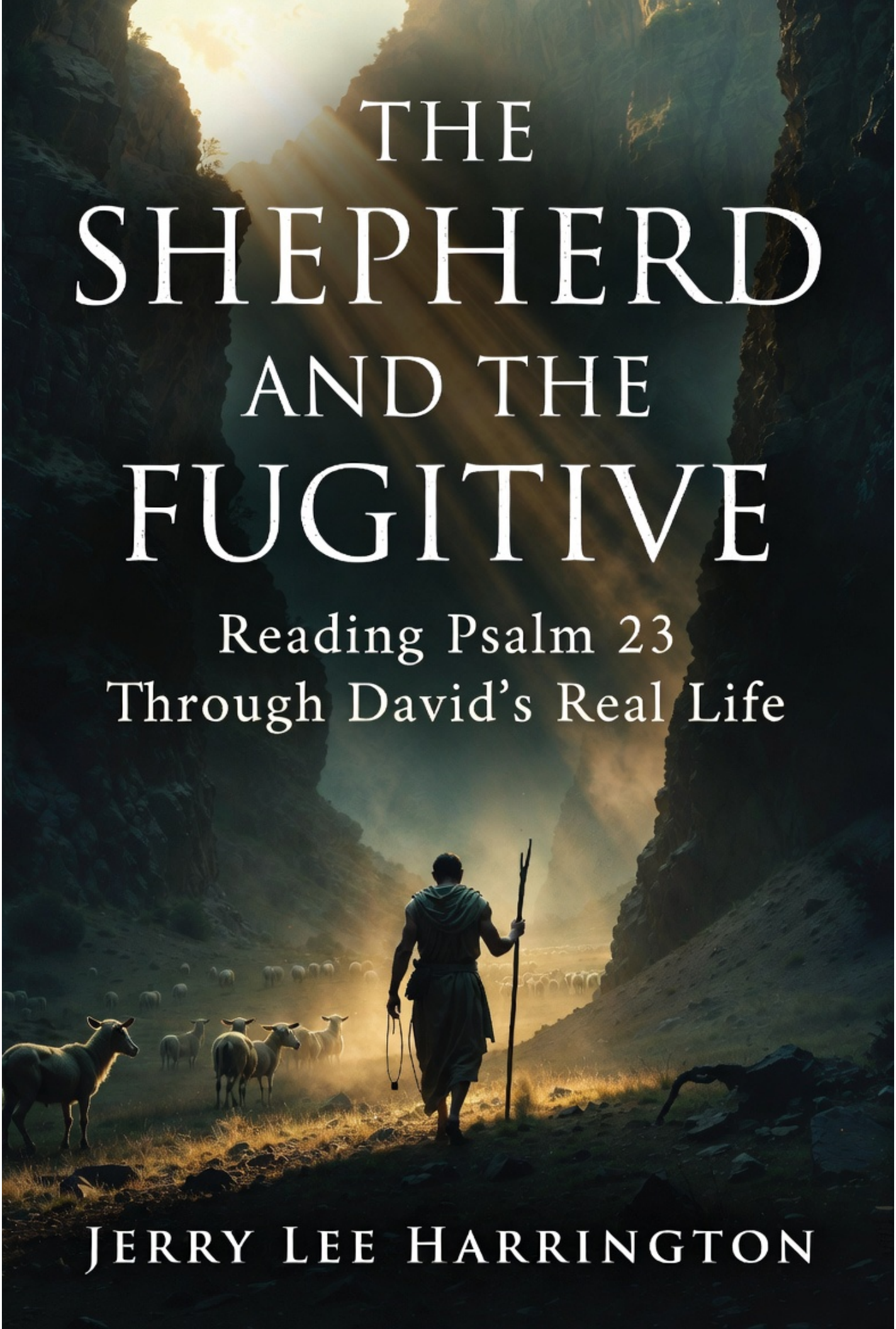
THE SHEPHERD AND THE FUGITIVE

Reading Psalm 23 Through David's Real Life



JERRY LEE HARRINGTON

The Shepherd and the Fugitive

Reading Psalm 23 Through David's Real Life

Jerry Lee Harrington

Psalm 23 is not a blueprint for what life will look like.

It is a declaration of what David believed about God

while his life often looked nothing like the psalm.

PART ONE — What a Psalm Is

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A psalm is poetry. It is prayer set to music. It is worship, lament, declaration, and raw honesty spoken to God or about God. The Psalms use image, repetition, contrast, and feeling to say what the heart needs to say when law, story, or doctrine will not do.

They are not commands like the law. They are not reports like the historical books. They are not orderly teaching like the epistles. Treating them as any of those things distorts them.

Many people read Psalm 23 as a promise: green pastures and still waters if you believe hard enough. Or as a formula: say these words and life will stay calm. Or they pour later theology into every picture until the poetry disappears. All three approaches miss what the psalm actually is.

Psalm 88 ends in darkness. No resolution. No upturn. Just shadow. Psalm 137 includes a cry for vengeance so violent most churches skip it. Psalm 22 opens with “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”—a shout Jesus Himself quoted from the cross. These are not theological errors. They are the real prayers of real people in real pain, preserved by God in the canon. He did not edit them. He kept them.

Psalm 23 belongs in this collection. It is not separate from the anguish of Psalm 22 or the fury of Psalm 137. It is the voice of a man who knew all of that and still said, “The Lord is my shepherd.”

That is what makes it remarkable. Not its calm. Its defiance.

To read Psalm 23 rightly, we must read it through David’s life, not over it.

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The Full David

To know David is to start with: David was a man after God's heart. Whatever else he became in life, the good and bad – David was oriented towards God. That orientation was the ground of everything God did for David—anointing him, protecting him, pursuing him even in his worst moments. That was the David God loved and honored back. And so…David was the shepherd boy overlooked by his own family until the prophet anointed him. He became a fugitive, sleeping in caves while the king he served tried to kill him. This was not a bad week. This was years. He was a warrior who stood against Goliath and led armies. He became king, brought the ark to Jerusalem, and danced before it like a man half his age.

He was also a sinner. He took another man's wife, arranged her husband's death, and lived with the guilt and the fallout for the rest of his life. The man who wrote "He leads me in paths of righteousness" had walked paths of calculated evil.

He was a father whose sons brought him grief that makes the rest of his biography look mild. Amnon raped Tamar. Absalom murdered Amnon, then launched a rebellion, drove David from Jerusalem, and slept with his concubines on the palace roof in public view. When Absalom was killed, David's grief was so total his general had to rebuke him for it: "O my son Absalom, my son, my son Absalom! Would I had died instead of you."

He was a man of blood. His hands were so stained God told him he could not build the temple. And this same man composed psalms of staggering tenderness, organized Israel's worship, and danced before the ark half-dressed in the streets.

He was not one thing. He was shepherd, fugitive, king, adulterer, murderer, broken father, warrior, and worshiper. Often simultaneously. This is the man who wrote Psalm 23.

Psalm 23 is not a description of how David's days usually felt. It is his deliberate choice to declare who Yahweh is even when everything around

him contradicted the words. It is a confession of trust spoken straight into contradiction.

Reading Psalm 23 “over” David’s life means smoothing everything out—pasting the psalm’s calm across his biography like a filter that softens the image. It does not soften. Reading it “through” his life means holding the psalm and the biography in the same hand. Letting the tension stay. And in that tension, finding a man who knew the worst and still declared his trust.

That is the Psalm 23 worth studying.

Approach

There are only 6 verses in Psalm 23. Yet its comfort, faith, and hope have filled shelves of books. My goal is to provide a lens to understand these 6 verses in a way that captures hope without false promises. This lens is simple: read David's words through David's actual life, not through our hopes for what his words might mean. That grounding will unlock understanding.

For each verse:

1. What the verse says
2. Historical interpretations
3. David’s actual life (foreshadowing: rarely matches the verse)
4. Tension – grappling with the difference between what David wrote in Psalm 23 and his lived life.
5. Declaration of faith – given David’s life, how do we understand the “believing in what’s hoped for” David’s words represent

6. Application: The Full Us – we, like David, are a mixture of good and bad, light and darkness. How will David's verses of faith translate to our lives in a way that's real and not impossible platitudes.

PART TWO — Psalm 23, Verse by Verse

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Verse 1

> *The Lord is my shepherd; I shall not want.*

What It Says

David makes a personal claim. Yahweh Himself is his shepherd. Because of that relationship, he states that he lacks nothing essential. The word “want” does not mean desire in the way we use it at a restaurant. It means deficiency. “I am not left without what I need.”

Notice what David does not say. He does not say “the Lord gives me things.” He says the Lord is something to him. The provision flows from who the Shepherd is, not from a transaction. Identity is the ground. Everything else grows from it.

Historical Interpretations

This verse has comforted people facing lack or uncertainty by reminding them that God sees and cares. Helpful: it roots provision in relationship, not in circumstances. Common overreach: turning “I shall not want” into a guarantee of constant abundance or the absence of real need. The shepherd image was not poetic decoration in David’s world. A shepherd was responsible for food, water, safety, and direction. The sheep trusted or did not. That was the entire relationship.

David’s Life

David knew what it meant to not want. He also knew desperate, gnawing need. As a fugitive he ate the consecrated showbread from the tabernacle because there was nothing else and begged food from a man named Nabal who refused him. He pretended to be insane in enemy territory just to survive another day.

As king he had everything—and his wanting took different, more destructive forms. He wanted Bathsheba. He wanted to cover his sin. He wanted Absalom to come home, and later wanted Absalom to stop trying to kill him.

How does “I shall not want” sound from a cave floor? How does it sound from a throne stained by murder?

“I shall not want” was not David’s resume. It was his declaration about who God is—spoken by a man who frequently found himself in desperate need.

The Tension

This verse does not guarantee the absence of need—material, emotional, or relational. It does not promise that faith will keep life comfortable. Readers who hear it as a contract will eventually feel betrayed—by the text or by God.

The tension is real: David writes “I shall not want” as a man who has wanted badly. This is not denial. It is a deeper claim—that even in the wanting, the Shepherd was present, and the ultimate deficiency was not real.

The Declaration of Faith

David is not reporting on his circumstances. He is staking a claim about God’s character. This is the grammar of faith: speaking about who God is in the teeth of evidence that might suggest otherwise.

> *God is my shepherd. Whatever I face, whatever I lack, He is enough.*

Application: The Full Us

Bring the full weight of your own life—your caves, your failures, your seasons of genuine lack—and still say, “The Lord is my shepherd.” Not because your life proves it. Because His character does.

There will be seasons where “I shall not want” feels like a lie. Say it anyway—not as denial, but as trust. Not as a formula that produces results, but as a

declaration about who is leading you. That is what David did. From a cave. From a throne. From a room that smelled like sin and regret.

Victory here is endurance: continuing to declare this truth when nothing around you confirms it. The Shepherd does not promise a life without want. He promises to be the kind of God you can trust even when want presses hard.

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Verse 2

> *He makes me lie down in green pastures. He leads me beside still waters.*

What It Says

Green pastures are where sheep eat and rest. Still waters—“waters of rest”—are calm pools sheep will actually drink from. Sheep will not drink from rushing water. The shepherd has to find or make quiet pools.

Watch the verbs. “He makes me” and “He leads me.” The shepherd is the agent. The sheep is not finding its own pasture or navigating to its own water. Rest and refreshment come from his initiative, not the sheep’s effort.

And notice: “He makes me lie down.” Not invites. Not suggests. Makes. A shepherd sometimes has to push a stubborn sheep to the ground. Rest, in the economy of God, is not always chosen by the one resting.

Historical Interpretations

Helpful: the images show God as the initiator of care. Common overreach: turning green pastures into “the Bible” and still waters into “the Holy Spirit” until the simple shepherd picture disappears under a pile of symbolism.

David’s Life

David knew green pastures as a boy watching sheep near Bethlehem. He also knew the desert—hiding in barren rock at En Gedi, fleeing barefoot and weeping during Absalom's rebellion, crossing the Kidron Valley into wilderness. Sometimes he lay in pastures. Sometimes he slept on stone.

The declaration is not about where David was. It is about who was leading him—even when the landscape was hostile.

The Tension

This verse does not promise you will always feel rested, nourished, or at peace. Some of the most faithful people in the history of faith have lived in extended seasons of exhaustion, deprivation, and relentless pressure. The verse speaks to God's character and intention, not to a guaranteed experience of meadows.

If you are in a wilderness right now, this verse is not a rebuke. It does not mean you missed a turn. It means the Shepherd knows where the pasture is, even when you cannot see it.

The Declaration of Faith

Even when my landscape is barren, my Shepherd is leading me toward sustenance.

Application: The Full Us

Rest is not always restful. Sometimes illness, loss, or failure forces you to stop, and only later do you see God was making you lie down. Sometimes the green pasture is not a pleasant season but a stripping away of everything until only the Shepherd remains.

And sometimes "still waters" is not a feeling of peace. It is the quiet that remains when everything else has been stripped away—quiet not because the noise stopped, but because you ran out of options and all that was left was God.

Do not measure your faith by the beauty of your current landscape. Measure it by whether you still believe the Shepherd is leading.

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Verse 3

> *He restores my soul. He leads me in paths of righteousness for his name's sake.*

What It Says

"Restores my soul" means bringing back, reviving, recovering something depleted or damaged. This is not maintenance language. It is recovery language. You do not restore something that was never broken. The word assumes damage. It assumes a soul that has been emptied and needs to be filled again.

"Paths of righteousness" are right paths—morally and practically. And then the qualifier that changes everything: "for his name's sake." Not for David's sake. Not because David earned it. God leads in right paths because God's own reputation and covenant faithfulness are on the line.

That phrase is a lifeline. It means God's guidance is not conditioned on your track record. It is grounded in His.

Historical Interpretations

Helpful: "for his name's sake" puts the weight on God's character. This is one of the clearest grace-statements in the Old Testament. Common overreach: softening "restores my soul" into generic emotional refreshment and missing the recovery-from-brokenness force of the Hebrew. This is not a spa day for the spirit. It is a soul pulled back from the edge.

David's Life

David's soul needed restoring more than once. After years hunted by Saul—depleted. After Bathsheba and Uriah—shattered. After his infant son died—

gutted. After Amnon's crime against Tamar—enraged and paralyzed. After Absalom's betrayal—broken in a way that even kingship could not repair.

And the paths of righteousness? David did not always walk them. He chose lust, deception, murder, and pride. Yet the grammar is clear: God leads him there. The agency belongs to the Shepherd. David's record of following was inconsistent at best. The Shepherd's commitment to leading never was.

The Tension

This verse does not promise your soul will always feel restored or that you will never wander. Some believers live years in exhaustion or numbness, and no amount of Bible reading or worship attendance flips a switch. Restoration and right direction are the Shepherd's work, not yours.

If your soul is depleted right now, you are not disqualified from this psalm. You are exactly who this verse was written for.

The Declaration of Faith

My soul has been broken. God brings it back. And His faithfulness is anchored in who He is, not in who I have been.

Application: The Full Us

Restoration implies prior damage. You cannot be restored if you were never broken. The fact that you need this verse is what makes it yours.

And if you have wandered badly, "for his name's sake" is the anchor. Your choices matter and consequences are real. But God's leading is not contingent on a clean record. It never was. Ask David.

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Verse 4

> *Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me; your rod and your staff, they comfort me.*

What It Says

This is the center of the psalm, and something shifts. David stops talking about God—“He makes me,” “He leads me”—and starts talking to God: “You are with me.” Third person becomes second person. The valley draws the poet closer. In the darkness, the relationship goes from described to addressed.

The Hebrew phrase often translated “valley of the shadow of death” can also mean “deepest darkness.” It refers to the most threatening place imaginable—a narrow ravine where predators lurk and danger is not metaphorical. Shepherds actually led sheep through such terrain.

Two tools: the rod—a short club for fighting off predators. The staff—a long crook for guiding sheep and pulling them from danger. One is for combat. The other is for rescue. Both are in the Shepherd’s hands. David says these instruments comfort him. Not the absence of the valley. Not the promise it will be short. The tools. The fact that the Shepherd is armed and present.

Historical Interpretations

This is the most quoted verse of the most quoted psalm. It has been spoken at more bedsides and gravesides than any other sentence in Scripture. Helpful: the promise is companionship in the valley, not escape from it. This distinction is one of the most important truths in all of Scripture. Common overreach: treating the rod and staff as guarantees of physical rescue or safety.

David’s Life

David walked real valleys with his eyes open. He crouched in caves while Saul’s army searched for him. He watched his closest advisor defect to Absalom. He received news that his sons had committed atrocities. He fled his own capital barefoot, cursed by Shimei along the road, abandoned by people who had eaten at his table.

David also knew the rod and staff. He spared Saul when he could have taken hsi life in the cave. He was protected through Philistine wars. He was guided back to Jerusalem after the rebellion collapsed. The Shepherd's tools were real in David's experience. But they did not prevent the valleys. They accompanied him through them.

The Tension

Read the verse again. It does not say "I will not walk through the valley." It says "even though I walk through." The valley is expected. It is not a detour from the life of faith. It is on the route.

And the verse does not promise the absence of fear. It declares a refusal to be governed by it: "I will fear no evil." This is a decision, not a feeling. There is an enormous difference between not being afraid and choosing not to let fear rule you. David is describing the second.

If you are in a valley right now and you are afraid, this verse does not condemn you. It invites you to say, even through the fear: "You are with me."

The Declaration of Faith

The valley is real. The danger is real. And the Shepherd is here. That is enough.

Application: The Full Us

Some valleys last years—chronic illness, grief that will not lift, a marriage that will not heal, a child who walked away. This verse does not promise a timeline. It promises presence.

The comfort it offers is not soft. The rod fights. The staff rescues. God's comfort is a Shepherd who will not leave and will not stop working—even when you have stopped asking for the valley to end and are only asking to survive it.

That is not lesser faith. That may be the deepest faith there is. Anyone can be faithful on a sunny day out in an orchard at harvest time. David is declaring his will—his choice, his promise—to hold to faith when sight is hard and danger is real, and to keep holding it in the middle of the struggle.

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Verse 5

> *You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies. You anoint my head with oil; my cup overflows.*

What It Says

The picture moves from pasture to table. The language shifts from shepherd and sheep to host and guest—ancient Near Eastern hospitality. To prepare a table for someone was to honor and protect them publicly. The anointing of the head with oil was a gesture of welcome and refreshment. The overflowing cup shows abundance beyond what is strictly needed.

And then the line that gives the verse its teeth: “in the presence of my enemies.” The table is not set behind locked doors. It is set in the open—in full view of everyone who wants to destroy the guest. The Host is making a statement: I will provide for this person, and I will do it where you can see.

Historical Interpretations

Helpful: the focus is on the Host’s generosity in the face of opposition. Common overreach: turning the table into the Lord’s Supper or the oil into the Holy Spirit—anachronistic imports that move past what David wrote. The strongest reading stays with the hospitality image. God is the host. David is the honored guest. The hospitality is conspicuously generous—offered not in safety but in exposure.

David’s Life

David lived most of his adult life surrounded by enemies—Saul, Philistines, Absalom, betrayers. God did sustain and honor him, but the enemies did not

disappear. The table was set in the middle of active conflict, not after it. The overflowing cup captured moments of lavish care, not a permanent state.

The Tension

This verse does not say your enemies will be defeated before you eat. It says the table is prepared where they can see it. Provision and opposition coexist. This is not triumphalism. It is defiant trust.

Some readers hear this verse and expect vindication—God rubbing their enemies' faces in blessing. But the text does not focus on the enemies. It focuses on the table. The enemies are scenery. The Host is the subject.

The Declaration of Faith

> *My enemies have not disappeared. But God has set a table. And I will eat.*

Application: The Full Us

You may have enemies—people, situations, forces that threaten you. This verse does not promise their removal. It promises that God will provide for you where they can see.

The defiance of this verse is quiet. It is not shouting at your enemies. It is sitting down and eating because the Host prepared the table. Your peace is not based on the absence of opposition. It is based on the presence of the Provider.

Sometimes the most faithful thing you can do is sit down and eat the meal in front of you. It is natural to want vindication, for God to defeat your enemies. The higher goal is to be satisfied with God. Let others watch or ignore. As for you, your focus is God and what He has set before you.

Some psalms cry out for God to deal with your enemies. Psalm 23 shows what it looks like when He doesn't—and you still trust Him.

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Verse 6

> *Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life, and I shall dwell in the house of the Lord forever.*

What It Says

"Surely" carries conviction. This is not a wish. It is settled confidence.

"Goodness and mercy." Biblical scholars note that the word translated "mercy" here speaks to something deeper than kindness—it speaks to loyalty, to a promise kept even when the promise-maker is broken. It is the love of a God who made a covenant and will not abandon it, even when the person in covenant breaks everything else.

These two—goodness and this covenant-loyalty—are presented as pursuers. David does not chase God's favor. God's favor chases David.

The psalm closes with dwelling—being at home in God's presence. "Forever" pushes past the immediate moment. David is looking beyond the valleys, beyond the enemies, beyond the table, to an enduring home.

Historical Interpretations

Christians have long read this as a statement about eternal life. That reading is not illegitimate, but David’s original meaning was likely more immediate: a life lived in the ongoing experience of God’s covenant faithfulness. Mercy is a covenant word—structural commitment, not sentiment. It speaks to a God who is bound by His own character to be faithful to His people.

David’s Life

Did goodness and mercy follow David all the days of his life? Yes. But not the way a surface reading suggests.

God’s mercy was present when David was anointed as a shepherd boy. It was present when he hid in the wilderness. It was present in Nathan’s confrontation—because the rebuke was itself an act of mercy. It was present after Absalom’s death, when David was restored to his throne.

Did David mean ONLY goodness and mercy would come to him all his days? Read the words again. There is no “only” word. God blessed David with goodness and mercy, richly so—but not ONLY so.

Goodness and mercy did not protect David from consequences—his family was destroyed, his shame was public, his reign was marked by grief. But mercy pursued him through those consequences. His son’s death was devastating, but it was also where David’s deepest repentance came. The rebuke from Nathan was humiliating, but it was merciful—it brought him back to his orientation toward God.

David’s story does not end with the wreckage.

God withheld the full collapse of David’s house during his lifetime. But the story stretches beyond him. It is no stretch to take “goodness and mercy will follow me” forward—to the God who kept His promise across centuries. From David’s line came Jesus. Goodness and mercy for all of us, for all time.

The Tension

This verse does not promise that every day will feel like goodness and mercy. Some days will feel like silence. Some years will feel like discipline. The confidence of “surely” is not the confidence of a man whose life has gone smoothly. It is the confidence of a man who has seen enough of God’s character to trust the trajectory—even when the present moment is dark.

The Declaration of Faith

God’s goodness and mercy are not behind me. They are chasing me. And my final destination is His presence.

Application: The Full Us

If you look back and struggle to see the goodness and mercy, look again—not for what you wanted, but for what was there. The provision that kept you going. The people who showed up. The correction that saved you from something worse. The fact that you are still here, still reading, still asking.

Mercy does not always look like blessing. Sometimes it looks like a prophet standing in your living room telling you the truth you did not want to hear.

And if the future terrifies you, the psalm ends with “forever.” Not because your circumstances will be eternal. Because your Shepherd will be.

PART THREE — The Whole Psalm, the Whole Life

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Psalm 23 is a unified declaration of trust.

It is not a description of how David's days usually felt. It is his deliberate, defiant choice to declare who God is—spoken by a man whose life regularly contradicted the words.

Peace Given and Endurance Required

The difference between peace given and endurance required runs through the whole psalm. Some lines describe moments of green pasture and still water. Others place us squarely in the valley. Both belong.

There are moments when God gives peace—real, inexplicable peace that settles into your chest in the middle of chaos. It is real. It happens. Scripture speaks of it.

And there are seasons when peace is not given. When the only thing available is endurance—the decision to keep going, to keep trusting, to keep showing up when nothing in you wants to. This is not failure. This is not second-class faith. It may be the deepest faith there is.

The life of faith is not perpetual rest interrupted by occasional valleys. For most of us it is the other way around—prolonged struggle punctuated by moments of green pasture. Both are legitimate. Both are held. We make a catastrophic mistake when we treat the first as the standard and the second as the exception.

The Shepherd Who Does Not Remove the Valley

The Shepherd leads His sheep into valleys. The verse says "even though I walk through." The path goes through the valley because the Shepherd chose the route.

In a world that treats hardship as proof of insufficient faith—or as a puzzle to be solved with the right spiritual technique—this is disruptive. The Shepherd does not remove all valleys. He is present in them. The promise is not a life without darkness. It is a presence within it.

This is harder to sell. It is also more honest. And it produces a faith that can survive the real world—not the faith of the untested, but the faith of someone who has walked through and is still walking.

What the Psalm Reveals

Psalm 23 does not reveal what your life will look like. It reveals what God is like.

He is a Shepherd who provides. A Shepherd who leads. A Shepherd who restores. A Shepherd who walks the valley with you. A Host who prepares a table in the presence of your enemies. A God whose goodness and mercy pursue you to the end.

> *This psalm does not promise a life like this. It reveals a God like this.*

And that is better. A life like the psalm can be taken from you by a single diagnosis, a single betrayal, a single phone call in the night. A God like the psalm cannot be taken from you at all.

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Go back and read Psalm 23 one more time.

Read it as David—the shepherd, the fugitive, the king, the sinner, the broken father, the worshiper. Read it with your own wounds, doubts, anger, and exhaustion. Do not clean yourself up for the text. Come as the full you.

The psalm can take it. It was written by a man who brought everything.

> *The Lord is my shepherd; I shall not want.*
>
> *He makes me lie down in green pastures.*

He leads me beside still waters.

He restores my soul.

He leads me in paths of righteousness for his name's sake.

Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death,

I will fear no evil, for you are with me;

your rod and your staff, they comfort me.

You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies.

You anoint my head with oil; my cup overflows.

Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life,

and I shall dwell in the house of the Lord forever.

This is not what life looks like. This is what God looks like.

And that has always been enough.

PART Four — The Man In the Arena

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About how this book was written. I'm a director of data and AI in my career and I use AI in many sophisticated ways as only someone with 40 years in IT is likely to do. This is no "ChatGPT, write me a book on Psalm 23". This book is my faith, my vision, my experience that only someone who's walked in Christ for decades can write.

I'm not a shepherd nor a theologian. I've been walking in Christ for 43 years and counting and my life does not look like Psalm 23. I'm the man in Ephesians 6:13 "… and having done all, to stand." Dirty, bloody, bruised – but still standing, still faithful.

I have had great moments of success and terrible moments of failure. Times of fear so intense I could barely breathe. I've had the joy of three healthy children and a marriage 34 years and counting. I've had loss of job time and again. Once so bad and long that my mind cracked and I suffered panic attacks daily and took a couple years to recover. I've done well in my career and I've gone bankrupt.

In other words – I'm human living life, making my way. I value my faith. It is the gem worth selling all others to buy. It's not, however, the life people think of when Psalm 23 is presented.

I hope I've given a faithful and wise interpretation to help all who, like me, God hasn't set in green pastures an cool waters every day of life. Those are seasons, not promises. If I were in the bible, I'd be much more like David than Daniel. Or Paul in Romans 7.

Like David, though, I will proclaim The Lord is My Shepherd! Hallelujah.